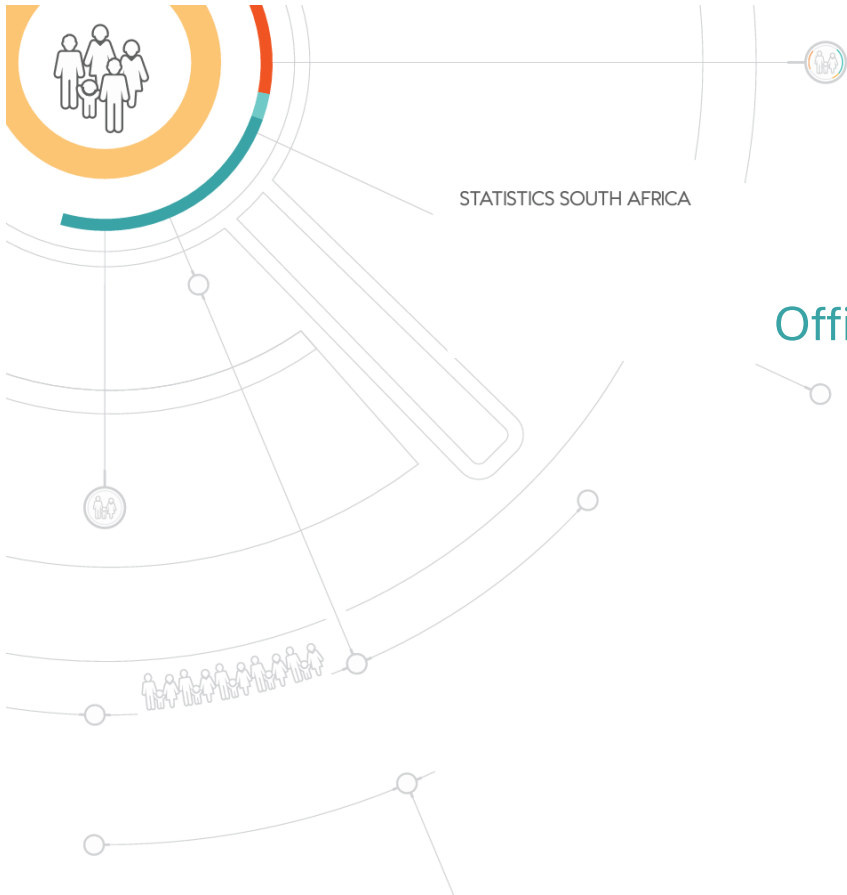




STATISTICS SOUTH AFRICA

Official Statistics in an AI age. How the data ecosystem impacts the work at Stats SA

STATISTICS SOUTH AFRICA
Ashwell Jenneker
Deputy Director General



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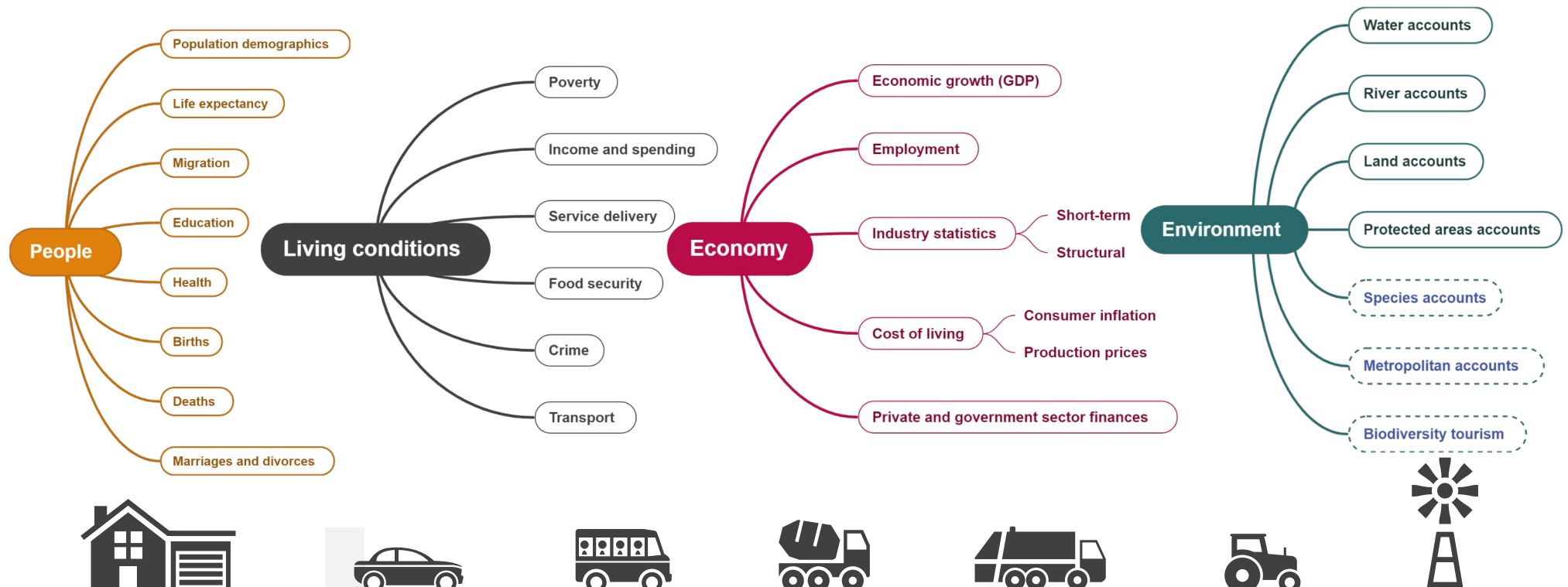
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Our Products (Key Statistical Releases – 275 per annum)



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The **South African** population in
2025 is estimated at

63 100 945



Source: Mid-Year Population estimates 2025

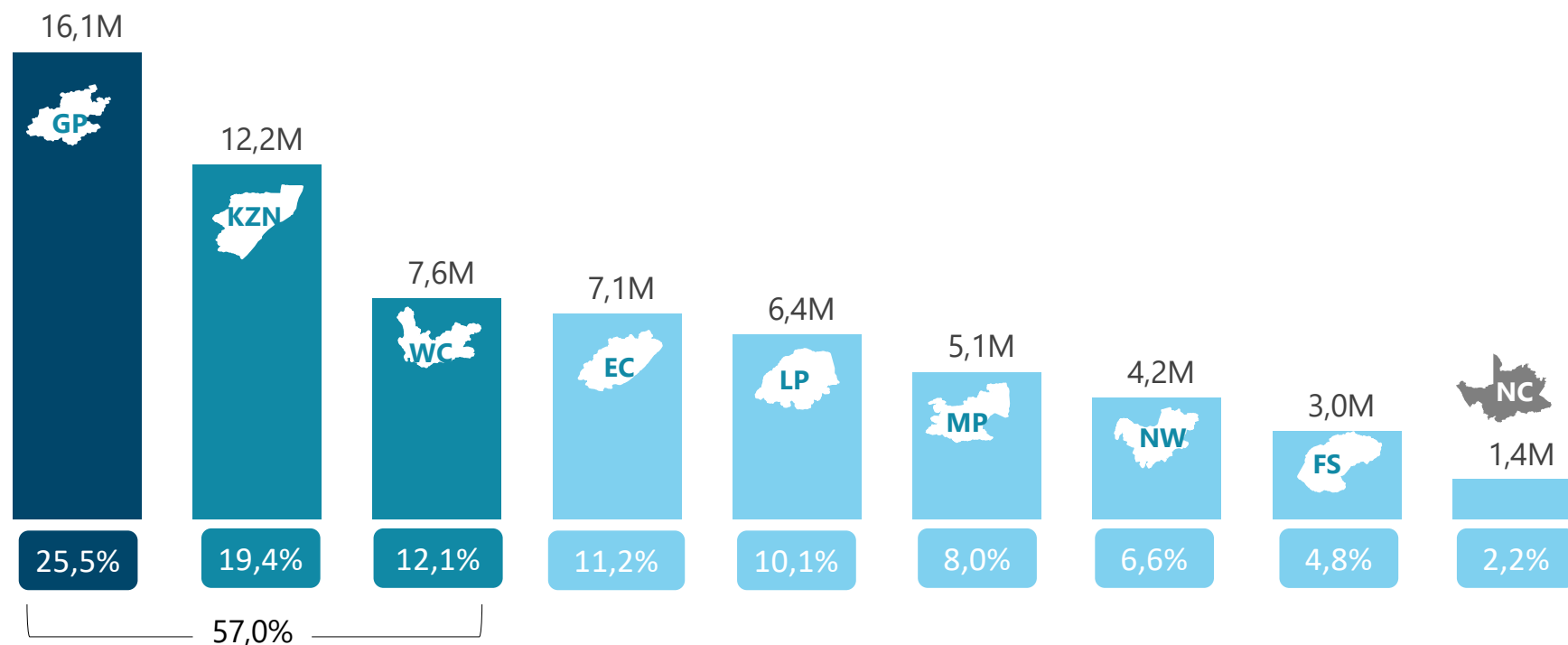


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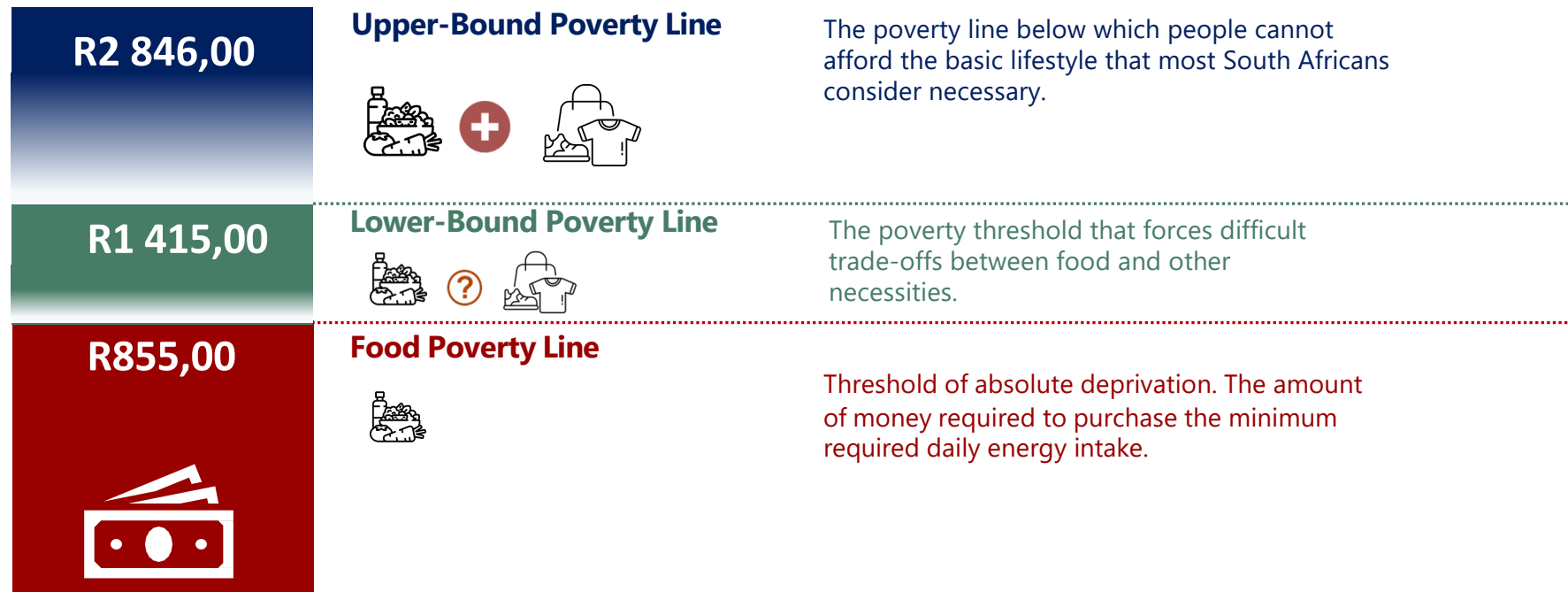
More than half of the population (36 million) live in 3 provinces. **GP remains SA's most populous province**

Mid-year population estimates for South Africa by province, 2025



Source: Mid-Year Population estimates 2025

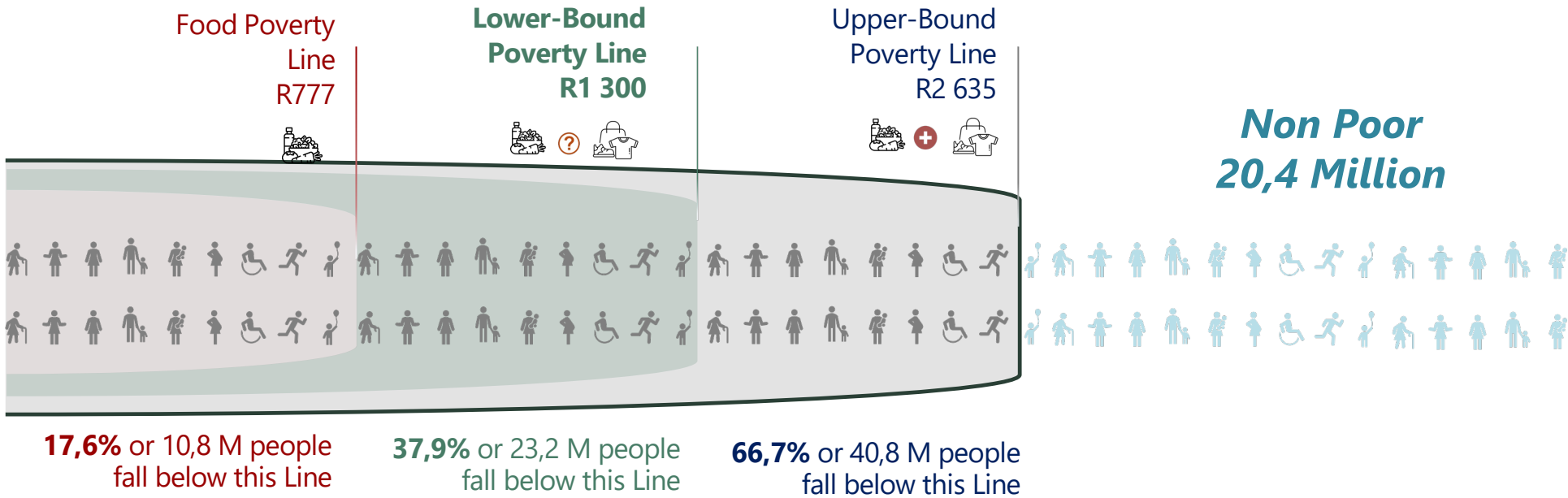
National poverty lines for 2025 (per person per month in Rands)



The poverty line series was rebased in 2025 using new household expenditure data sourced from the Income & Expenditure Survey (IES) 2022/23.

37,9% of South Africans (23,2 Million) *fall below* the **Lower-Bound Poverty Line**

Money-metric **poverty headcounts in 2023** and **national poverty lines for 2023** (per person per month in Rands)



This is threshold of absolute deprivation. The amount of money required to purchase the minimum required daily energy intake

The poverty threshold that forces difficult trade-offs between food and other necessities.

The poverty line below which people cannot afford the basic lifestyle that most South Africans consider necessary.

The poverty line series was rebased in 2025 using new household expenditure data sourced from the Income & Expenditure Survey (IES) 2022/23.



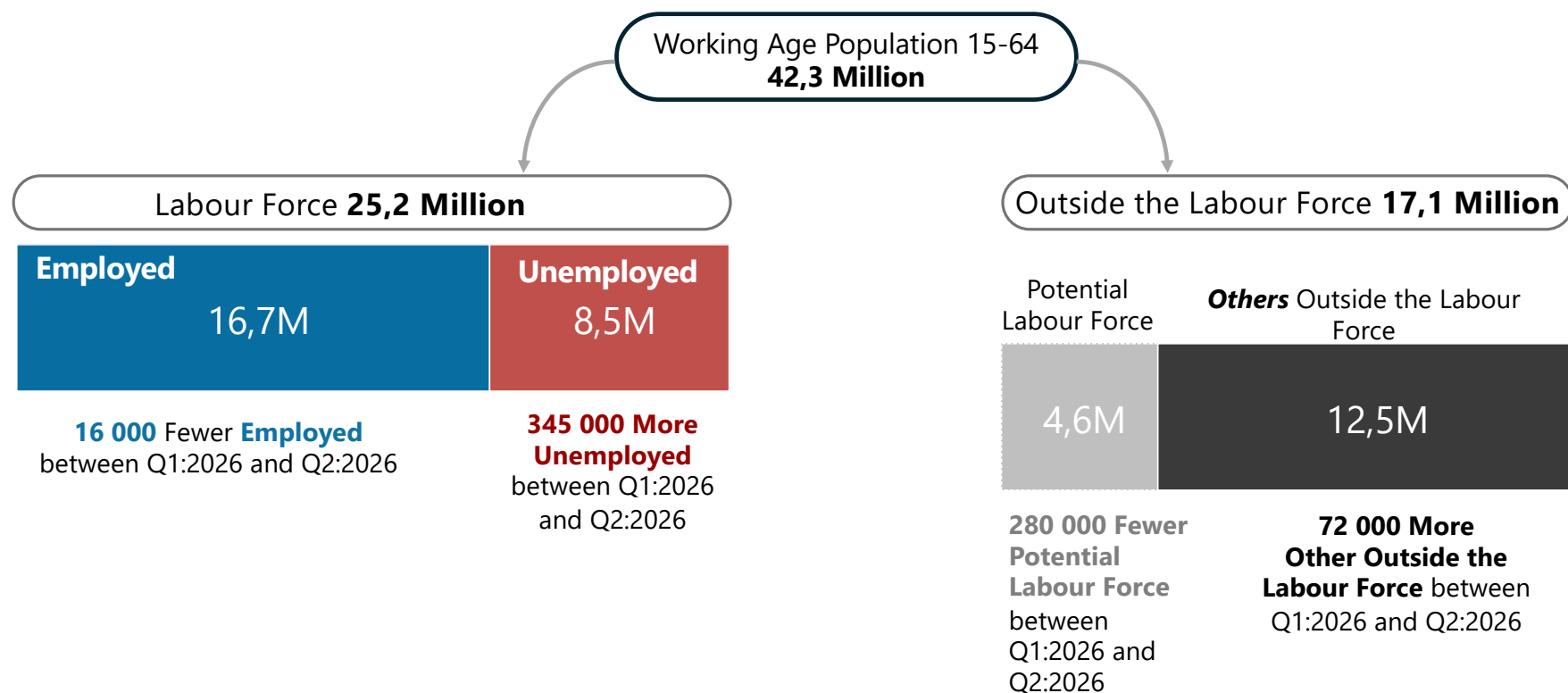
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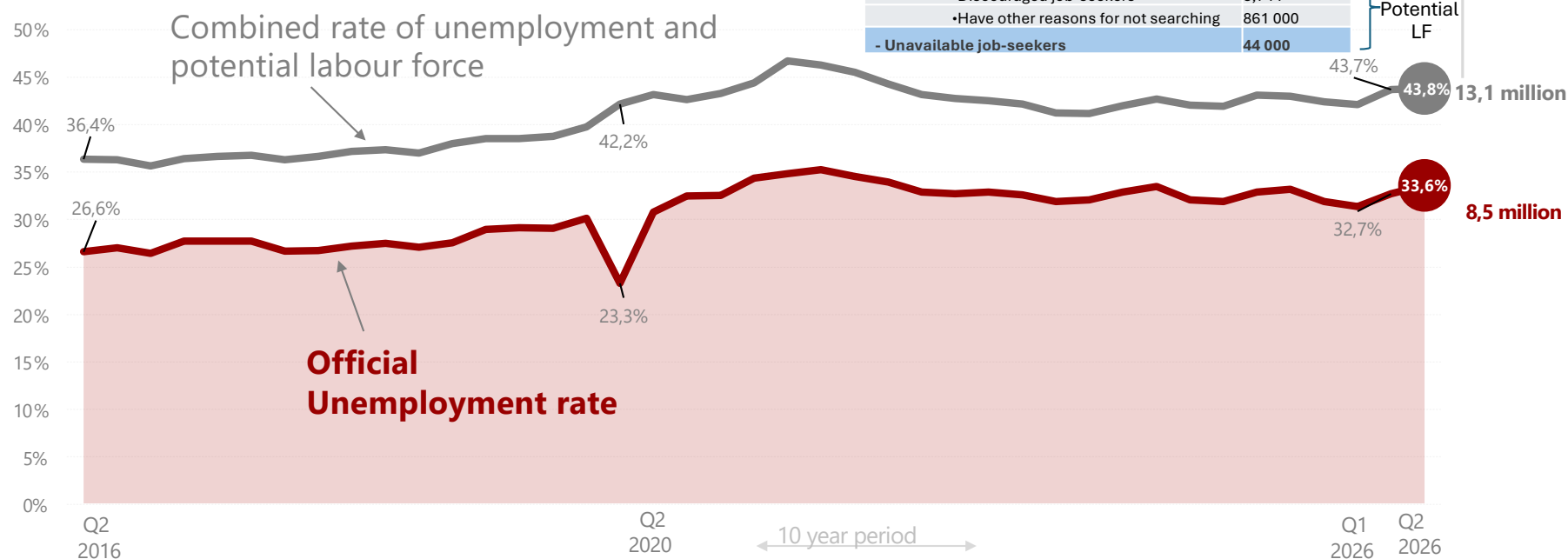


There were **345 thousand more people unemployed** in Q2:2026 than in Q1:2026.



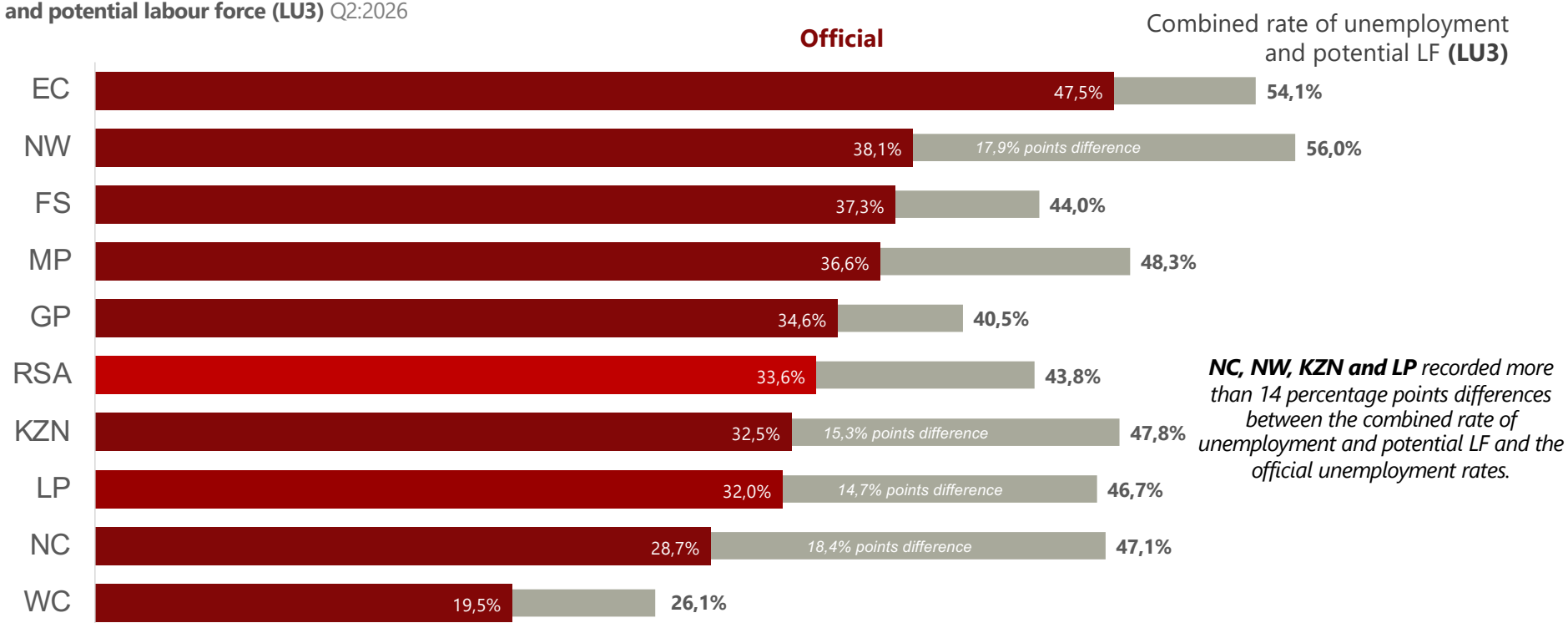
The combined rate of unemployment and potential labour force (LU3) **increased by 0,1 of a percentage point to 43,8%** in Q2:2026 compared to Q1:2026.

Official UR vs combined rate of unemployment and potential LF (LU3): Q2:2016-Q2:2026



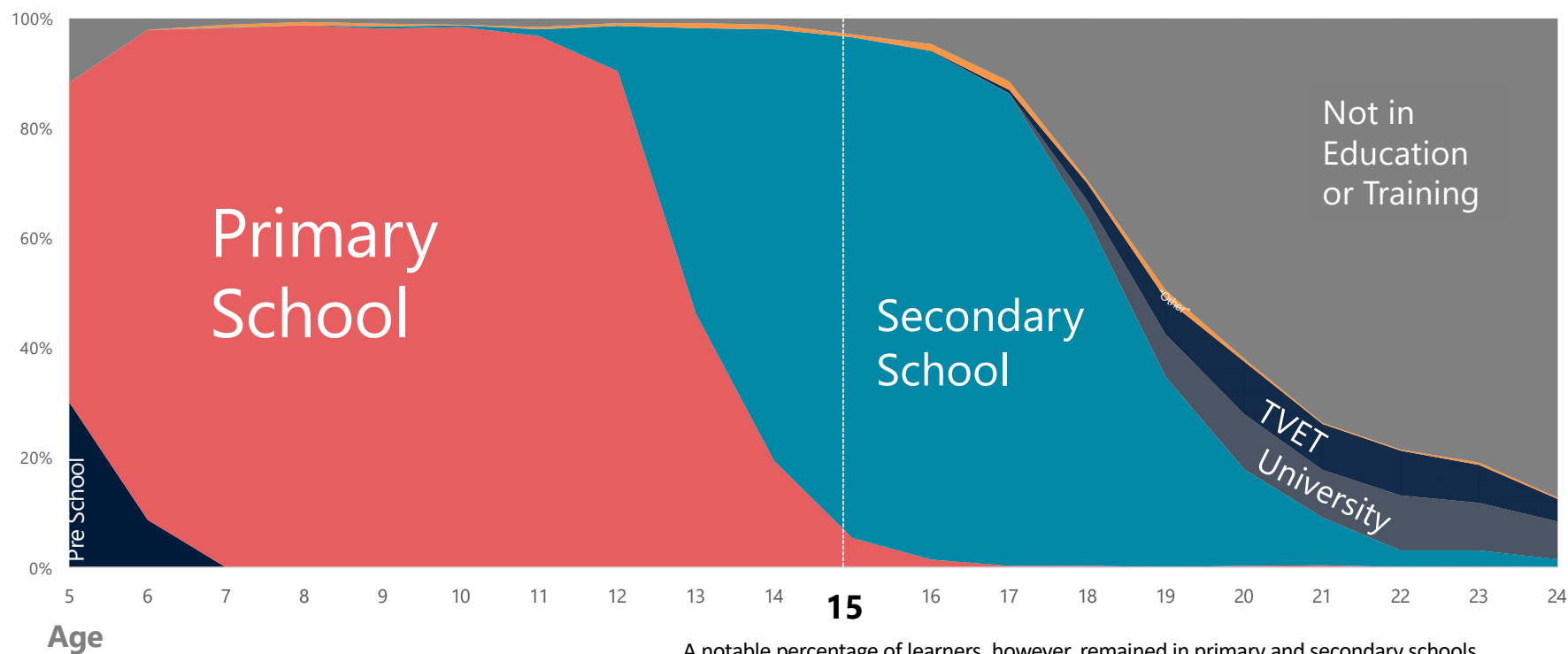
NW (56,0%) recorded the **highest combined rate of unemployment and potential LF** in Q2:2026, followed by **EC** (54,1%).

Provincial unemployment rates: **Official Unemployment rate** vs **Combined rate of unemployment and potential labour force (LU3)** Q2:2026



PARTICIPATION IN EDUCATION INSTITUTIONS was **almost universal (96,6%)** by the age **of 15 years** (the last compulsory school age)

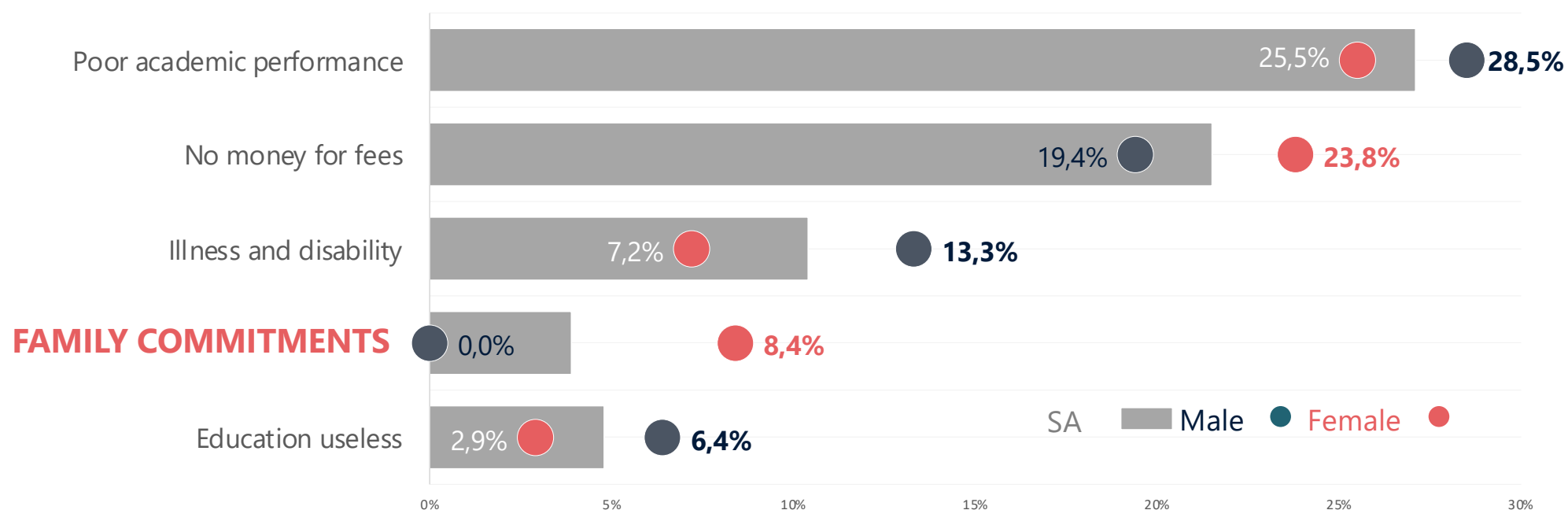
Type of educational institution attended by individuals aged 5–24 years, 2025



Source: GHS 2025

TOP REASONS for males not attending school was **POOR ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE**, with *large gender disparity* in **FAMILY COMMITMENTS** as a reason for not attending school

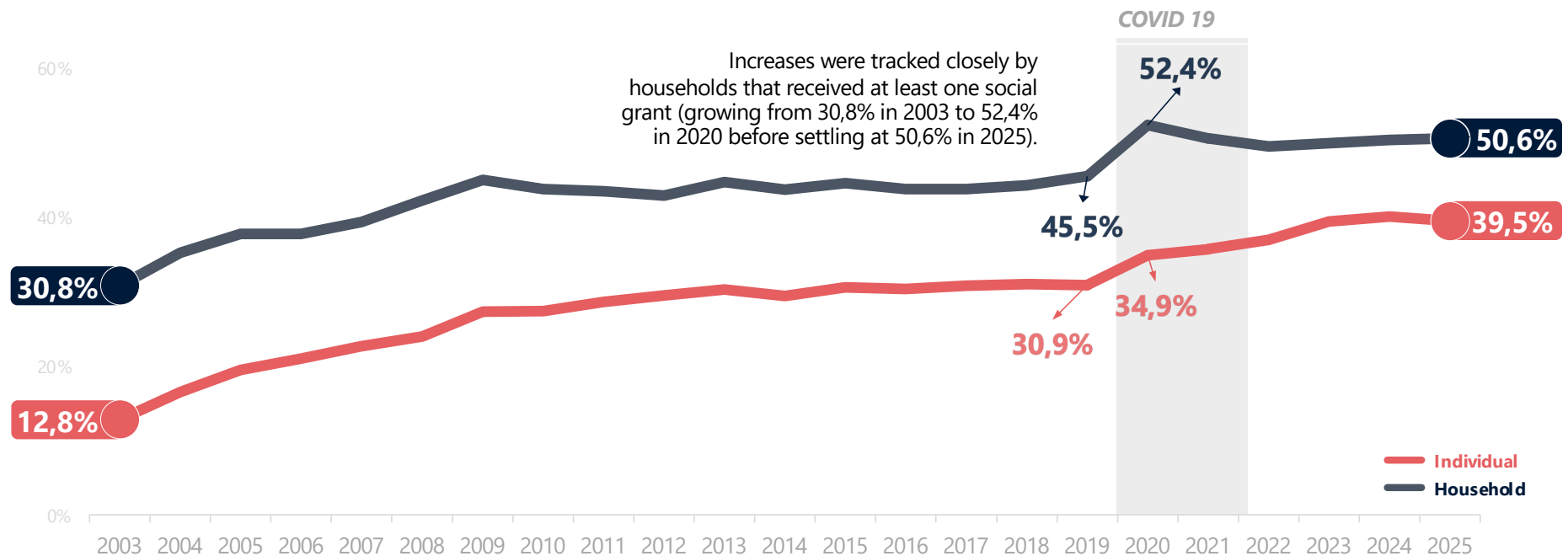
Percentage distribution of selected reasons given by individuals aged 7 to 18 years for not attending an educational institution, by sex, 2025



Source: GHS 2025

The percentage of **INDIVIDUALS** that benefited from **SOCIAL GRANTS** increased steadily from 12,8% in 2003 to approximately 31% between 2017 and 2019 before increasing to **39,5% IN 2025**

Percentage of households and individuals who have benefited from social grants, 2003–2025

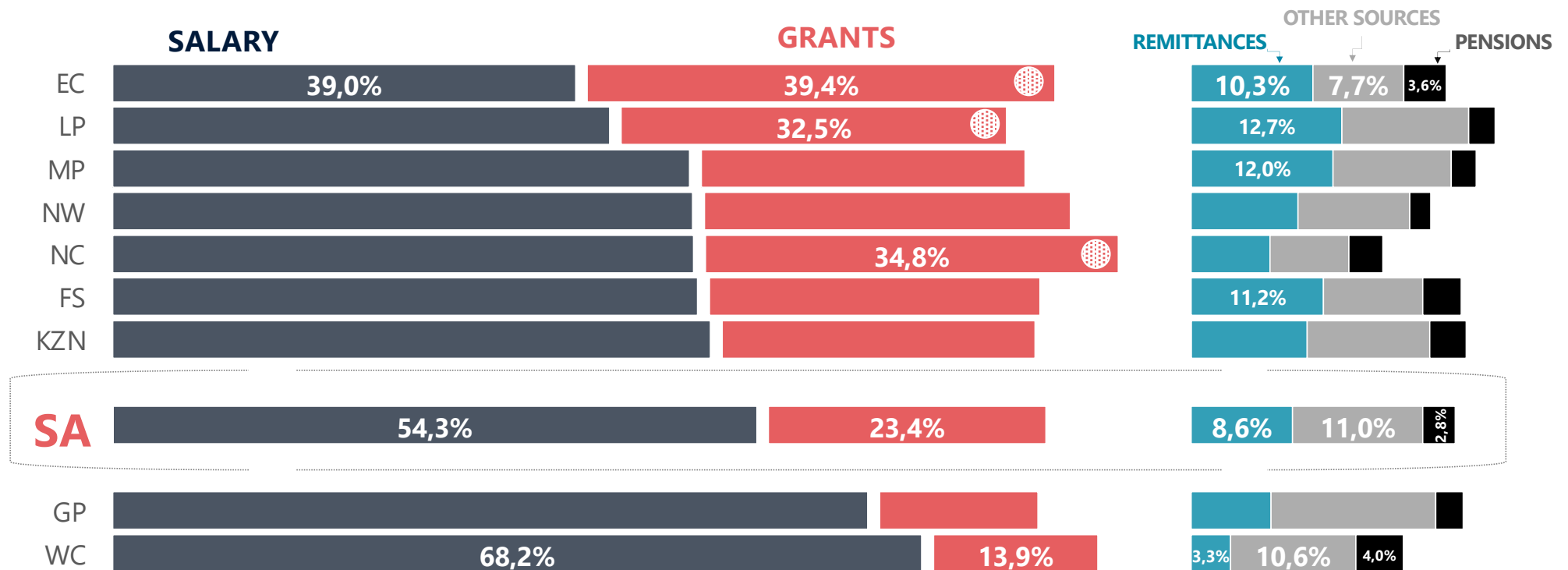


Source: GHS 2025

GRANTS were particularly important as a main source of income for households in **EASTERN CAPE (39,4%), NORTHERN CAPE (34,8%) AND LIMPOPO (32,5%)**

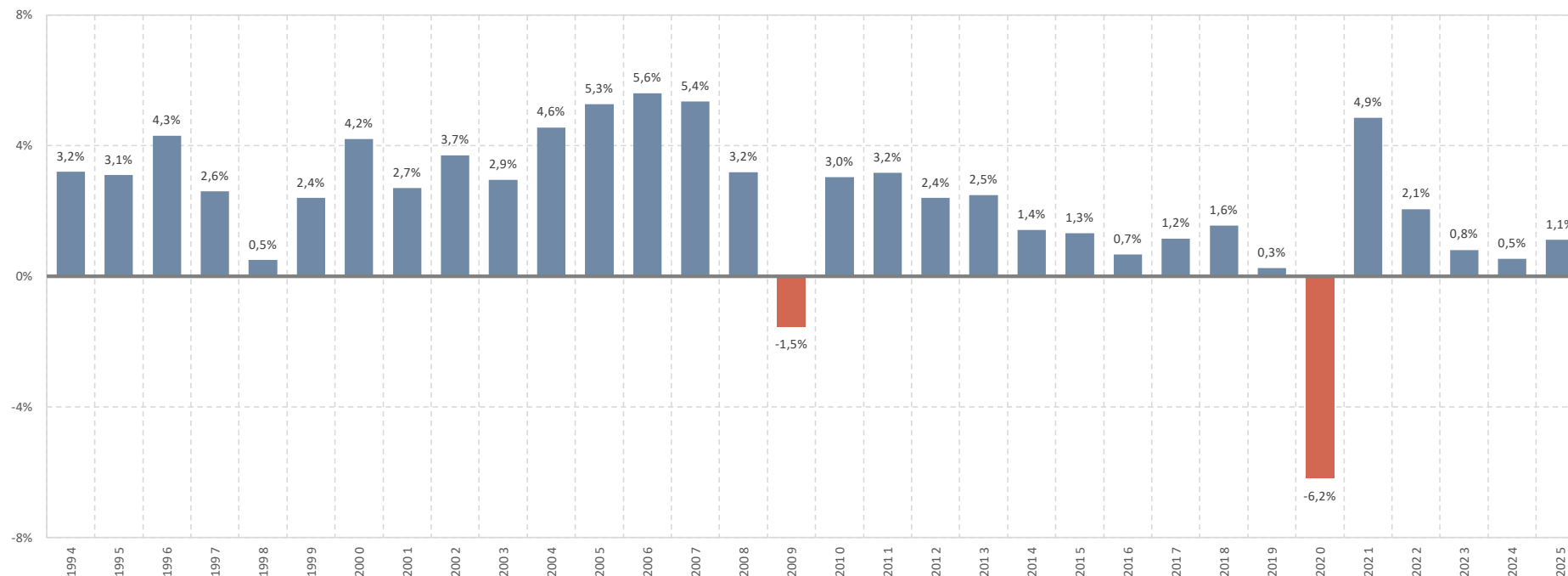
Percentage distribution of main sources of household income by province, 2025

Source: GHS 2025



South Africa's economy grew by 1,1% in 2025

Annual GDP growth rate (constant 2015 prices)



Source: Gross Domestic Product, Q4 2025,



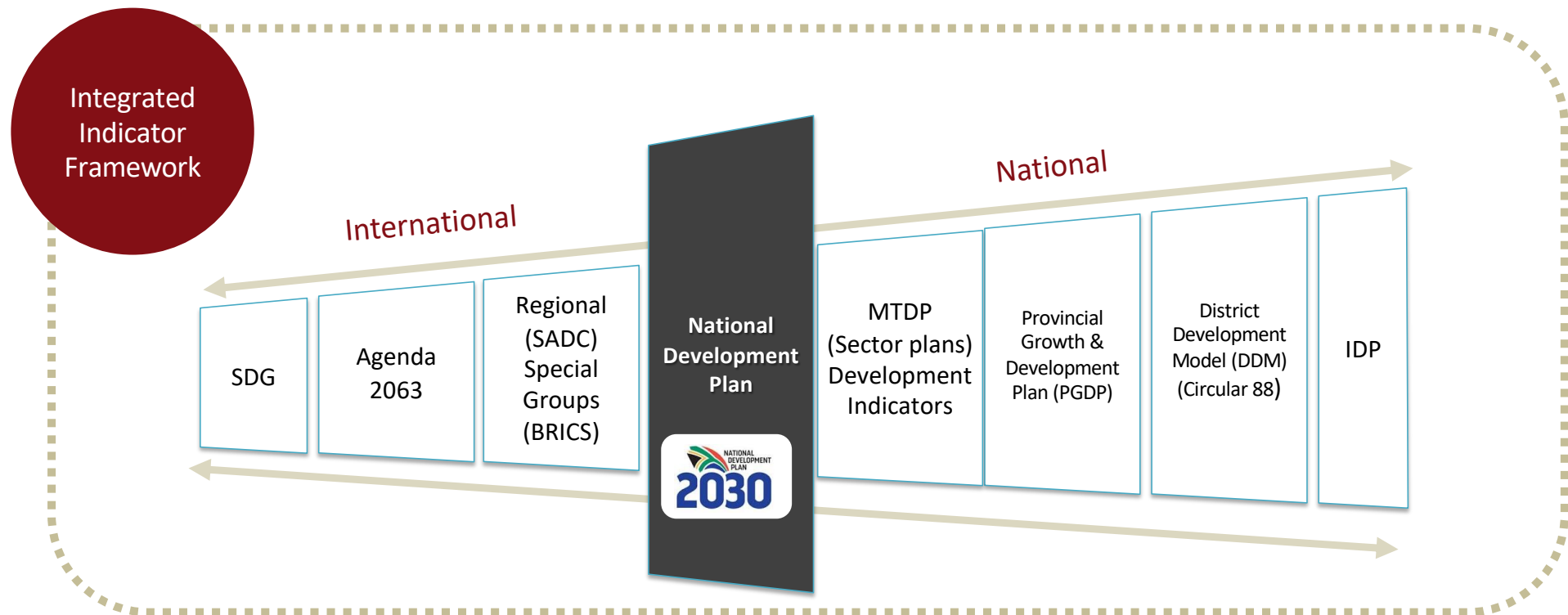
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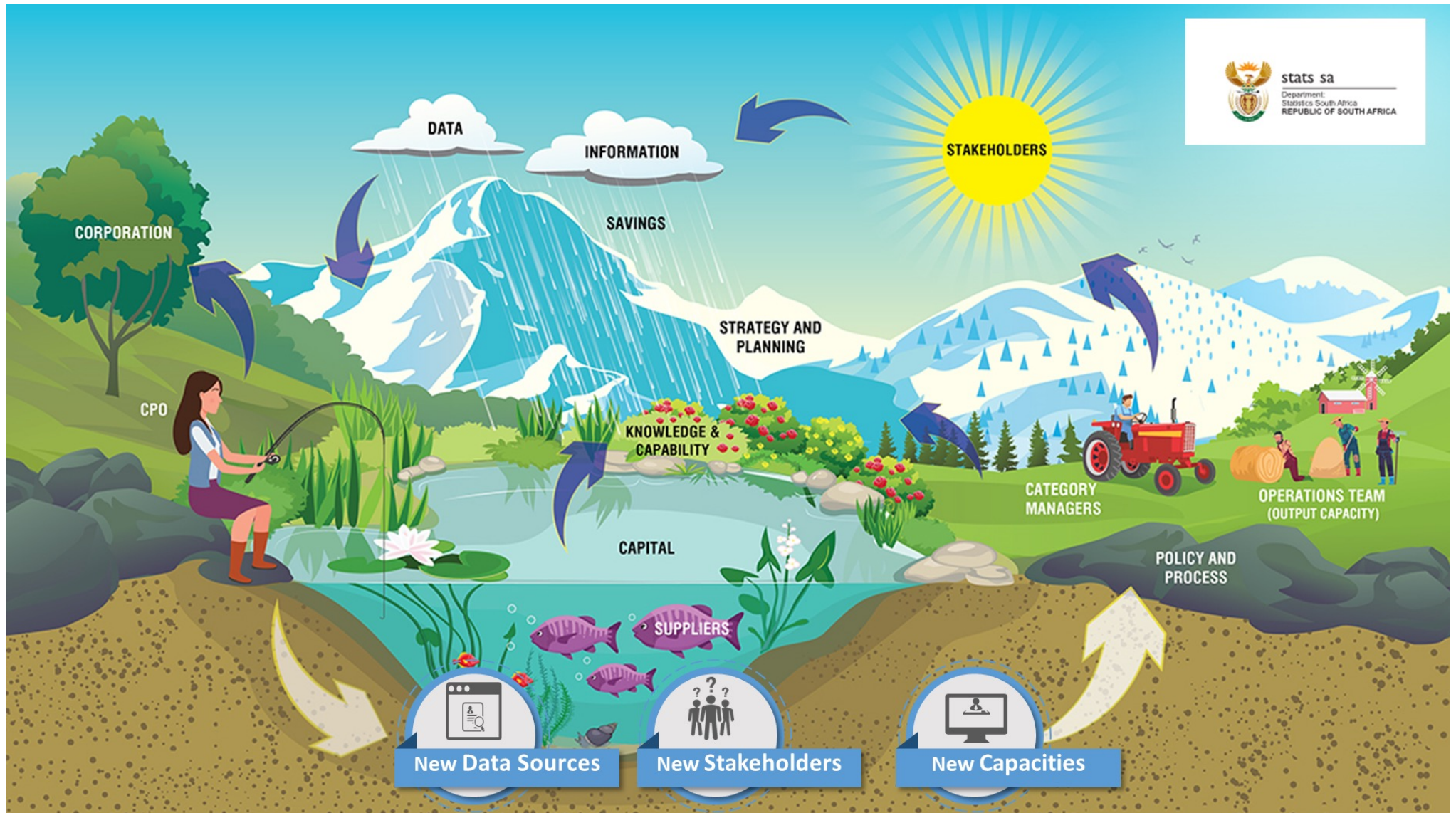


Policy demand alone outstrips available official data availability





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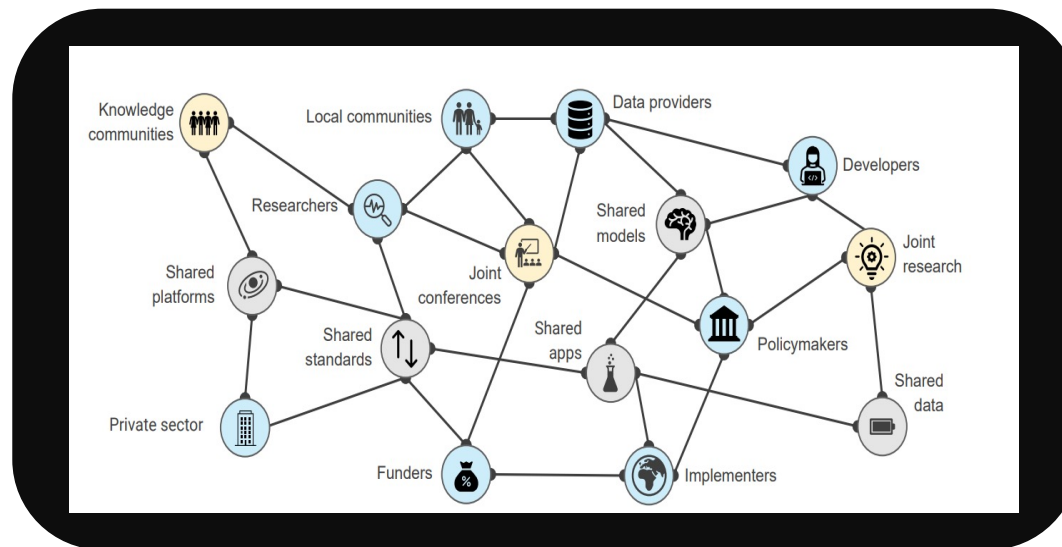
Key elements in the data ecosystem

Data producers

Data Users

Data Governance

Data Infrastructure



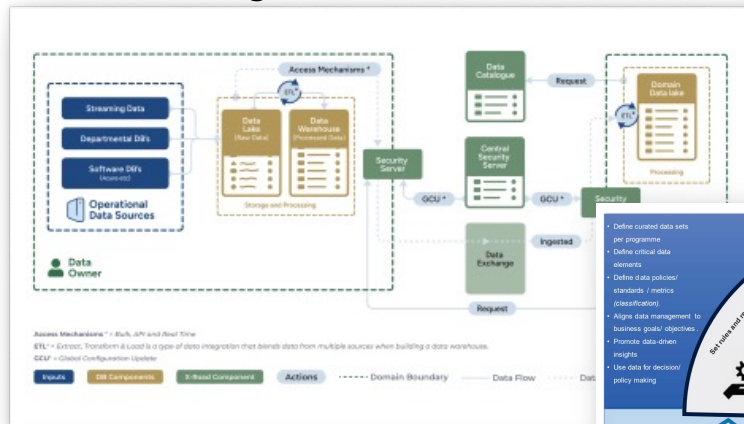
Data Intermediaries

Capacity and Literacy

Collaboration and Partnerships

Launch of new initiatives: Where do we stand?

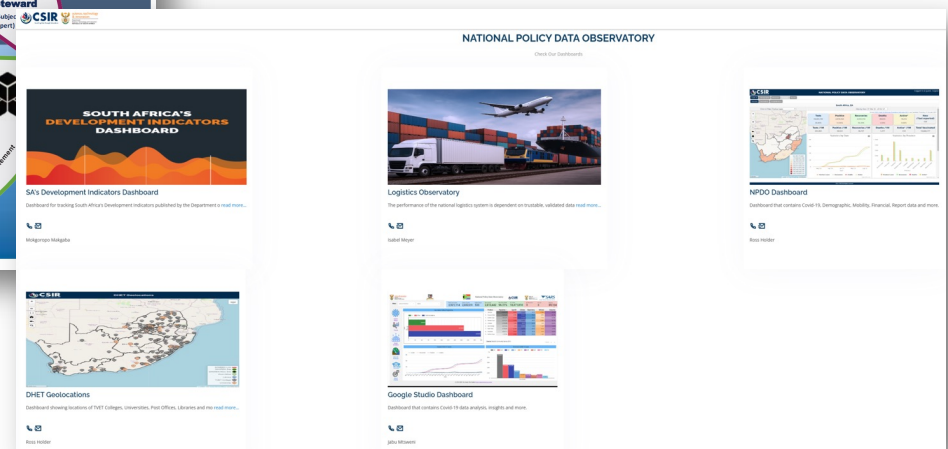
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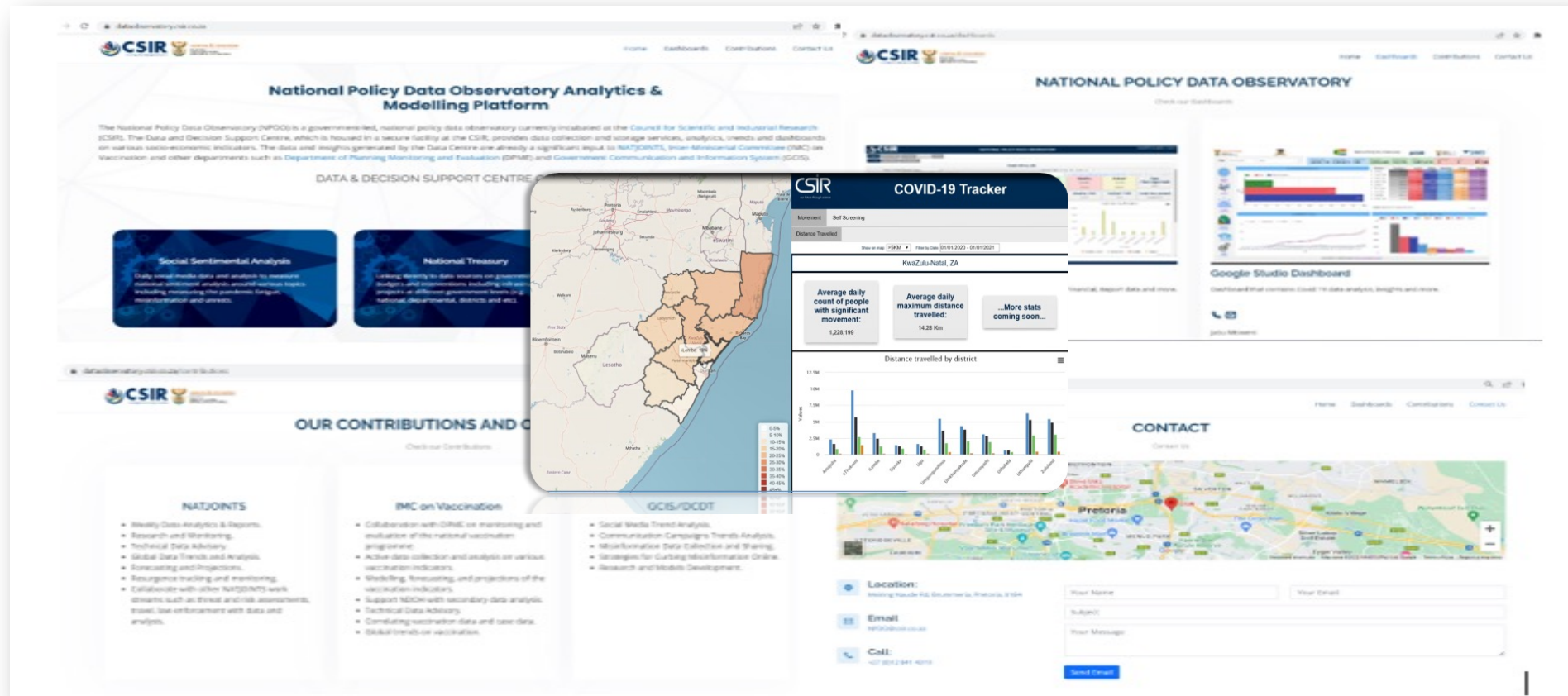
Public Service Data Governance Framework



National Policy Data Observatory (NPDO)



National Policy Data Observatory Overview: Technical Platform

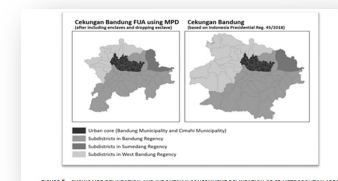


Exploring Partnerships with World Bank to create a National Mobile Network Data Programme

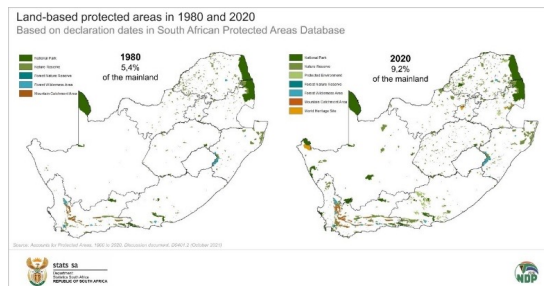
Stats SA lacks continuous national statistics on commuting patterns, origin-destination flows, peak travel demand, inter-provincial mobility and urban mobility dynamics.

DATA INSIGHTS THAT COULD BE ACHIEVED

- 1 Daily commuting, municipality to municipality
- 2 Peak-hour and hourly mobility flows
- 3 National origin–destination matrices (district, metro, province)
- 4 Travel demand by weekday, weekend and season
- 5 Congestion indicators — bottlenecks, corridor demand
- 6 Rural accessibility to schools, clinics, employment
- 7 Public transport demand at rail, BRT and taxi ranks
- 8 Freight-movement proxies at logistics hubs and ports



Active participation in UN Global Platform



South Africa is the current Chair of the *Committee of Experts on Big Data and Data Science for Official Statistics*

The finance committee of the Global Platform, chaired by South Africa, aims to develop a sustainable business model and marketing plan for the Global Platform in order to manage cost and raise funds

Stats SA is testing Artificial Intelligence for Environment and Sustainability (ARIES) for System of Environmental and Economic Accounts (SEEA Explorer to investigate how it can help to produce automated land and ecosystem accounts



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